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People Don't Want a Mosque Here: Destruction of Minority Religious Sites as a Strategy of Nationalism

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Abstract: Religious sites are often at the center of confrontation. Groups frequently clash over the structures and the historical narratives surrounding sacred spaces. Religious sites encompass deeply entrenched meanings for groups of all backgrounds. These spaces represent identity, tradition, history, family, and belief systems. For minority groups, their religious sites can help provide a sense of belonging and serve as a monument to their history in the community. Due to their symbolic importance, religious sites are also vulnerable to violence by outside groups. Destructive acts targeting religious architecture and symbols are common throughout the world, but are especially frequent in identity-based conflicts, such as in Bosnia. However, the study of these attacks and their relationship to nationalist movements, particularly in Asia, has not been adequately studied. This article examines the destruction of Islamic sites in three distinct countries and contexts: India, Myanmar, and Xinjiang, China. In each case, Muslims are religious minorities and face varying levels of persecution. This article argues that the destruction of religious spaces and symbols has been used both literally and symbolically to claim a space for the dominant group and assert a right to the associated territory. The elimination of Muslim sites is part of a broader attempt to engage in a historical revisionism that diminishes or vilifies Muslims belonging in the region.

Keywords: Hindu nationalism, Buddhist nationalism, Xinjiang, India, Babri Masjid, Rohingya

On August 5th, 2020 Narendra Modi, the prime minister of India, participated in a stone laying ceremony at the construction site of the new Rama temple in Ayodhya. The site stood at the location of the Babri mosque

before it was destroyed in 1992 by thousands of *Kar Sevaks*, Hindu volunteers. Many Hindus claim the site is the birthplace of the Hindu god Rama and an ancient temple which was destroyed by Muslims in the sixteenth century. While at the ceremony, Modi addressed a national television audience using language steeped in Hindu rhetoric:

> A long wait has ended today. . . . A grand temple will now be built for our Ram Lalla who had been living under a tent for many years. Ram Janmabhoomi has been freed from this interference which was on for centuries. . . . Shri Ram's temple will become the modern symbol of our culture, eternal faith and national spirit. And this temple will also become a symbol of the collective resolve power of [millions of] people. . . . There is no aspect of life where our Ram does not inspire us. There is no such feeling of India in which Lord Ram is not seen. Ram is in the faith of India, Rama is in the ideals of India. Rama is in the divinity and philosophy of India. (Modi 2020)

Although India is a multi-religious and constitutionally secular country, the policies and language of Modi and the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) have fused the Indian state to Hindu nationalism. Since the 1907 Hague Convention, international law formally prohibits the destruction of religious and heritage sites. More recently, the International Criminal Court has prosecuted individuals for destroying buildings of historic or religious importance (Swart 2020). In 2016, Ahmad Al-Faqi Al-Mahdi was convicted for his role in attacks on heritage sites in Timbuktu (Swart 2020). The normalization of the Babri Masjid destruction and the building of the Rama temple serves as a dangerous precedent about what tactics are acceptable when addressing contested religious sites. The Babri Masjid incident, however, is not an isolated case. This paper explores how the destruction of minority religious sites is a strategy of nationalism in India, Myanmar, and China.

Literature

Benedict Anderson refers to the nation as "an imagined political community—and imagined as both inherently limited and sovereign" (Anderson 2006: 6). As a nation, members feel connected to one another through the bond of community, which may include language, ethnicity, religion, territory, or a combination of these. Nationalism, however, involves excessive identification with one's nation and belief in its superiority. Nationalism often relies upon the construction of narratives that emphasize a group's historical connectedness to the land. While building this connection, groups may also attempt to minimize or even erase the historical evidence of other groups within the same territory. Archaeological evidence may be used to further promote na-

tionalist discourse, manipulate historical narratives, and assert ownership of a territory (Kohl and Fawcett 1995; Coningham and Lewer 2000; Kohl 1998).

Architecture and cultural sites are meant to reflect the ethnic and historic makeup of a country. Various authors have discussed how archaeology creates belonging and meaning (Stovel, Stanley-Price, and Killick 2005). Kaldor emphasizes how architecture can be utilized in the process of legitimizing the nation (Kaldor 2004). Likewise, destruction of archaeological sites can demonstrate that certain sites no longer belong in the new ethno-religious state. Acts of cultural destruction are thus used strategically as a weapon of psychological warfare (Auwera 2012).

As nationalist movements attempt to rewrite historical narratives, they may utilize what is called a backward-looking nationalism that erases or villainizes specific groups in the past. Backward-looking nationalism means nationalists want to emphasize a revised version of history where the belligerent ethnic group is the actual victim (Kaldor 2004). Through such victimization, the nationalists can justify violence toward a historical antagonist. For instance, Serb nationalists considered Ottoman rule responsible for ending Serbia's golden age. During the Bosnian war, Serb nationalists memorized anti-Ottoman/Muslim verses by nineteenth-century Serbian Poet-Prince, Petar II Petrović-Njegoš, to inspire and justify their aggression. During his reign, Njegoš wrote verses that glorified violence and promoted the destruction of Muslim sites and villages (Sells 2002). According to Njegoš, the creation of a greater Serbian ethnic state was not possible without such destruction. To restore the glory of the former Serbian civilization, the nationalists felt they had to correct what they considered historical wrongdoings toward them.

Destroying artifacts of Ottoman domination was considered a symbolic way to reclaim the territory for their ethnic group. When Serb nationalists destroyed Bosniak mosques and architecture, they later denied the historical presence of Muslims in those areas (Sells 2002). Sites of architectural and historical importance, such as the Aladza mosque, known as the jewel of Islamic Balkan architecture, were destroyed (Riedlmayer 2002). In his investigation of damage and destruction at 392 Muslim sites throughout Bosnia, Riedlmayer finds that the damage was intended to erase the multi-ethnic history of the country while also reconstructing the collective memory of a nation and replacing it with a newer ethnocentric version (Riedlmayer 2002).The goal of this was also to minimize the incentives of Bosnian Muslims to return, symbolizing their lack of belonging and connection to the area.

Although intentional destruction of heritage sites is not formally considered genocide, the systematic use of it can serve as evidence that genocide has occurred. During the International Criminal Tribunal for the former Yugo-

slavia, the Trial Chamber emphasized that coordinated attacks on religious and cultural property alongside physical attacks of a specific group can demonstrate evidence of intent to destroy a group (Abtahi 2001). Consequently, the destruction of mosques, libraries, and cultural centers were considered evidence of acts of genocide. Annex eight of the Dayton Peace Agreement established the Commission to Preserve National Monuments. The eighth annex formally ended the Bosnian War and was considered foundational in the parties coming to an agreement.

Not surprisingly, cultural heritage sites are especially vulnerable during conflicts. As group polarization increases, the willingness to target cultural heritage sites may likewise increase (Sørensen and Viejo-Rose 2015). Sites that are targeted may be directly tied to the underlying cause of the conflict (Brosche et al. 2017). For example, the 2012 destruction of the burial tombs in Timbuktu, Mali was carried out by Islamic insurgents that considered the tombs blasphemous. The destruction of the Bamiyan Buddhas by the Taliban may have been a tactic to signal their strength and ideology to the rest of the world. Although Buddhists were no longer a part of Afghanistan, the symbolic attack was intended to shock the world and signal the resolve of the Taliban to the Western world (Knuth 2006; Brosche et al. 2017).

While targeting cultural heritage sites can be a strategy used by states or rebels, it can also be utilized in the mobilizing stage of a political movement. Symbols and architecture can create a rallying effect that incentivizes new membership. Both states and rebel groups utilize symbols such as flags, national anthems, and cultural heritage sites to evoke pride in their identity. To the group, symbols can provide cohesion, while also creating strict parameters regarding the in and out group. Symbols and myths serve an important part of nationhood and belonging and a perceived threat toward those symbols can help increase recruitment efforts (Smith 2009).

Militants may also use their own heritage sites strategically to store weapons and launch attacks. This tactic was used by Sikhs at the Golden Temple in 1984 when fighting an insurgency with the government of India. Because Sikhs did not expect the Indian government to target their holiest sites, they took refuge in the site along with their weapons. Once the Indian government attacked and damaged the site it severely damaged the relationship between Sikhs and the Indian government, ultimately leading to anti-Sikh riots and the assassination of Prime Minister Indira Gandhi by her Sikh bodyguards. In Myanmar, the government often burnt village churches in the Kachin state because they were used as a center for recruitment during both phases of the Kachin Civil War from 1961 to 1994 and 2011 to 2021 (Sithu 2016).

Targeting cultural sites can also be financially opportunistic. Looted antiquities and relics potentially can create an attractive income stream for rebel groups or corrupt governments. Capturing and controlling territory that holds important cultural and historical significance creates a new revenue for the group (Baker and Anjar 2012). For example, ISIS gained substantial revenue from the illegal antiquities trade beginning in 2013 (Al Azm 2015). From 1970–1998, organized looting rings stole tens of thousands of antiquities from temples during Cambodia's period of instability (Mackenzie and Davis 2016). Widespread looting of museums also took place following the US-led invasion of Iraq and Afghanistan (Rothfield 2009). More recently, close to 2000 artifacts were looted from war torn Yemen (Khalidi 2017).

Finally, it is important to consider the capacity and the willingness of the state both to participate in and prevent targeted acts of destruction In many authoritarian countries the state may actively participate or support the destruction of heritage sites and use its strength to limit the response by the targeted groups. However, state weakness may prevent the state from effectively protecting cultural sites. Empirically, the destruction of cultural property occurs most often in weak, failing, or failed states because the state lacks the capacity to protect the property (Auwera 2012).

In the cases explored in this paper, the state has utilized its role to support the destruction of minority cultural heritage sites in varying capacities in India, Myanmar, and China. In the case of India, the BJP opposition party alongside Hindu nationalist paramilitary organizations used the destruction of the Babri Masjid to mobilize existing supporters and attract new followers. Within the same decade, the BJP became the ruling government. These three cases represent nationalism in three distinct political regimes: a democracy (India), a semi-authoritarian state (Myanmar), and a one-party authoritarian system (China). In India, the Vishva Hindu Parishad (VHP)/Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) maintain close ties to the BJP. In Myanmar, Buddhist militias and the state participated in the destruction of Muslim sites throughout the country, specifically in the Rakhine state. In China, the destruction has primarily been carried out by the state. The cases demonstrate that similar tactics are used across diverse regime types against religious minorities to promote nationalism. The destructive tactics demonstrate the risk to religious minorities in different political systems.

India: Religious Nationalism Becomes State Sanctioned

Modern independent India has been pulled in many different philosophical directions. On one end, elites associated with the dominant Indian National

Congress Party (INC) have traditionally promoted a vision of secularism, a word explicitly added to the Constitution in 1976 during Indira Gandhi's 21-month state of emergency. "The Emergency" period was an attempt to quell what she and the INC considered internal disturbances, including those relating to Sikh and Hindu Nationalists. The word secularism was poorly defined in the Indian Constitution, leaving the meaning up to interpretation. However, the opponents of secularism were more clearly defined by the Gandhi administration. Any organization considered to be a threat to public order was banned. The RSS, a Hindu paramilitary organization, became one of the main targets of arrests during The Emergency (Jaffrelot 2007). The Sikh community in Punjab was also widely targeted. Estimates suggest that nearly 30% of the 140,000 arrests were Sikhs (Grewal 1990). The instability in Punjab later escalated into a Sikh separatist insurgency in 1981.

On the other end of the spectrum, Hindu nationalists have attempted to make Hinduism central to India's identity. While Hindu nationalist organizations were not new to India, the tactics and philosophy of the Gandhi administration during The Emergency helped give rise to a more organized movement. The *Hindutva* ideology sought to unite fragmented Hindu divisions into a more united, albeit mostly upper caste, organization. The arrests and perceived suppression of the RSS during The Emergency helped build upon a narrative of Hindu oppression. Hindu nationalists asserted that secular politicians, religious minorities, and their allies, particularly in the universities, sought to diminish Hindu identity and expression of faith. From the 1980s onward, the Hindu nationalist organizations RSS and VHP became increasingly powerful alongside the growing power of the recently established BJP. Communal violence between Hindus and Muslims also began increasing alongside the growing power of these movements (Wilkinson 2005). Several features became the key foci of the Hindu Nationalist movement as it gained momentum, but none more than the disputed site of the Babri Masjid.

Babri Masjid

During colonial rule, architectural preservation was used to assert authority (Anderson 2006). In India, the British saw themselves as caretakers of Indian archaeology that might otherwise be destroyed amid Hindu-Muslim tensions and what the British considered Indian "carelessness" (Rai 2009). In 1857–1858, Indians of all religious backgrounds fought in the Sepoy Mutiny against the increasing power and presence of the British in India. The Sepoy Mutiny was fought throughout much of Central India, with some of the strongest areas of resistance in Awadh, a region in modern Uttar Pradesh near

Ayodhya. The rebels fought under the auspices of Bahadur Shah, a Muslim whom they declared the emperor of Hindustan. Both Hindus and Muslims recognized Shah as their leader which led British officials to note they could not use the "divide and rule" strategy against the two religions in this instance (Chandra, Tripathi, and De 1972). Once the British defeated the Indians, they began to refer to Muslims as "ferocious fanatics" (Metcalf 1965). This stirred a narrative of Hindu-Muslim historical division and built upon growing contention between the two religious groups. It also further aided in ongoing revisionism about the historical relationship between Hindus and Muslims prior to British colonization (Truschke 2016).

At the same time as the Sepoy uprising, the British developed close relationships with the Nirbani Hindu sect in Ayodhya. The Nirbani had provided refuge to the British during the mutiny and later received land in exchange for their loyalty (Ratnagar et al. 2004). The British began relying on the Nirbani's historical accounts to write reports on the history of the area, specifically of the Babri Masjid (Srivastava 1991). The Nirbani had seized the mosque in 1853 claiming it was the birthplace of the Hindu God Rama. The Babri Masjid had been built in the sixteenth century during the reign of Mughal emperor Babur. However, the mosque became a site of increased contention following independence in 1947.

In 1949, Hindus held a nine-day reading of the *Ramayana* and placed statues of Rama and Sita at the site of the mosque. This act of defiance by Hindus caused a confrontation with local Muslims.. Following this confrontation, the mosque was locked. Over the next decades, both Hindus and Muslims initiated several lawsuits claiming ownership of the property. The mosque aroused increasing interest from the VHP and RSS in the 1980s. The groups held ceremonies at the location in 1983 and formed a committee that called for the liberation of the Rama temple and the removal of locks (Bacchetta 2000). During the 1980s, there was also increasing popularity of the Ramayana TV series which spurred countrywide interest in the god Rama. The television show reinforced the city of Ayodhya as the birthplace of Rama and subsequently drew attention to the location of the Babri Masjid (Bacchetta 2000). In 1986, to placate demands of the growing Hindu nationalist movement, Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi had the locks on the mosque removed and allowed Hindus to worship at the site but did not permit Muslim prayers (Ratnagar 2004).

In August 1990, the BJP launched its national political campaign under the slogan "Towards Ram Rajya" meaning the rule of Rama. Alongside this slogan, the party also launched a commemorative *Ram Rath Yatra* campaign in the months leading up to the election. With a truck constructed like an

ancient Hindu chariot, BJP President L.K Advani launched a month-long rally, visiting temples throughout India with the Babri Masjid as the end destination. Advani was joined by thousands of fervent supporters during his campaign (Bhatt 2001). Two years later, the mosque was destroyed by thousands of *Kar Sevaks*, including many who had participated in the Rath Yatra. The site would become a politicized landmark that would define Indian politics until the present-day.

The destruction of the Babri Masjid is perhaps one of the most defining examples of architectural destruction by modern religious nationalists. The destruction of the mosque, however, is about more than just the elimination of a particular Muslim religious site. Instead, the mosque was seen as a symbol of historical subjugation, harking back to the dominion of Mughal emperor Babur. Hindu nationalists assert that despite being the demographic majority, they are historical victims of occupation and violence at the hands of minorities, including the British and Muslims. To remove the symbol of historical subjugation is to correct historical wrongs.

The destruction of the mosque was strongly condemned by the ruling Indian National Congress (INC) and thus the act of destruction was not done under the auspices of the ruling government at the time. However, the leaders of the BJP, RSS, and the VHP who mobilized around the destruction of the mosque would go on to become key leaders in the BJP. The party made the construction of the Rama temple a top campaign priority. Eventually, the party won national elections and formed a successful coalition in 1998, ending the long dominance of the INC.[1] Although the initial reign of the BJP was short, the party rose to power once again in 2014, and was reelected in 2019 with decisive margins that essentially prevented opposition to their legislative measures.

A New Era of Hindu Nationalism

Since gaining a large legislative majority in 2019, the BJP has utilized its power to quickly enact legislation that is considered anti-Muslim by many human rights activists. The most prominent examples of this are the Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA) and the elimination of Article 370 and 35a. The CAA fast tracks the citizenship of Buddhist, Christian, Hindu, Jain, and Sikh migrants from neighboring Muslim countries. Essentially, a path to citizenship is provided for migrants of all religious backgrounds except Muslims.

[1]The BJP won the largest number of seats in the 1996 election but failed to form a tangible coalition. The BJP won the 1998 election but dissolved after thirteen months and then formed a successful government coalition in 1999.

Critics worry that the CAA alongside the proposed National Register of Citizens (NRC) will disproportionately impact Muslims. The NRC, which seeks to identify and detain anyone without proper documentation, was previously implemented in the northeast state of Assam as a mechanism of locating residents, primarily of Bangladeshi origin, without documentation. The final list of citizens in Assam contained 31 million names and excluded 1.9 million applicants, primarily Bangladeshis. In response to criticism from poor Hindus whose names were also not on the register, Home Minister Amit Shah reassured them that Hindu, Sikh, Jain, and Christian names not on the NRC need not worry (Amit Shah 2019). The publication of the Assam NRC in August came amid a heightened sense of worry following the August 5th constitutional order eliminating Article 370 and 35a. Article 370 had been enacted in 1949 and allowed Kashmir to have its own constitution, flag, and autonomous governance. Article 35a was enacted in 1954 to maintain the unique cultural heritage of Kashmir by preventing non-Kashmiris from purchasing land in Kashmir. The elimination of these two articles weakened constitutional protections for Kashmiris and threatened to facilitate a demographic transition that Hinduize Kashmir. Combined, these August 2019 measures created a sense of worry among India's Muslims about their future and safety within the country under the governance of Hindu nationalists. Protests erupted throughout the country against the NRC and CAA in December 2019. In February 2020, the protests in New Delhi escalated into some of the country's most violent riots in decades.

The exclusionary measures of the BJP have come under increased international scrutiny. The Council on Foreign Relations notes that the leadership of Prime Minister Modi and the BJP have heightened anti-Muslim sentiment and disenfranchised millions of Muslims. Indian Muslims continue to face social barriers that limit equitable access to education, housing, and political power and representation (Maizland 2020). Consequently, Indian Muslims live with higher rates of poverty and discrimination while having limited avenues to address grievances. Ongoing acts of institutionalized discrimination may also make India's Muslim population, particularly the youth, vulnerable to extremist views. The destruction of the Babri Masjid served as a catalyst that helped empower a new generation of Hindu nationalists and created a precedent to assert dominion over Muslim sites throughout the country. Ultimately, the institutionalization of Hindu nationalism through the BJP has helped legitimize anti-Muslim policies and actions.

Myanmar: Buddhist Nationalism through State and Militia Collaboration

It is difficult to know the exact demographics of Myanmar due to manipulations in the Census, government suppression of information, and exclusion of certain religious and ethnic groups. However, based on available information, the population of Myanmar is approximately 88% Buddhist, 4% Christian, and 4% Muslim. Myanmar is ethnically diverse with over 100 different ethnic groups, with the majority of the population being Bamar (68%), and many other large ethnic groups including the Shan (9%), Karen (7%), Rakhine (2%), and Rohingya (2%) (Wade 2019). Since independence in 1948, the government of Myanmar has considered the Rohingya, who primarily live in the Rakhine state, to be illegal aliens from Bangladesh. According to Myanmar officials, the British brought the Rohingya to the region during the colonial era and they likewise should have left at independence in 1948. The Rohingya, however, have lived in the region for more than a century, with evidence of a presence in the region as early as the eighth century (Wade 2019).

Buddhism has been a defining feature of Myanmar's state identity since independence. Burmese Independence leader Aung San originally gave hope to ethnic and religious minorities with his promotion of secular democratic ideas and multiculturalism. Unfortunately, this vision was left unfulfilled following his assassination in July 1947. Following increasing instability after his death, the military took an increasing role as a caretaker government. By 1962, a military junta was in power and would hold that power until gradual democratization efforts in 2010. The democratic experiment, however, appeared to end abruptly following the military coup on January 31, 2021.

There have been several ethnic based uprisings since independence throughout the country including the Kachin in Kachin state, the Karen (Kayin) in Kayin state, the Chin and Rohingya in the Rakhine state, and the Shan in the Shan state. The junta responded harshly for decades and implemented its Burmanization policy, whereby it imposed the dominant Bamar ethnic group's form of Buddhism and culture on the rest of the country (Berlie 2008; Rogers 2013). The semi-democratic government under Aung San Suu Kyi left many hopeful that it would bring an end to the internal violence, but for the Rohingya, the targeted violence escalated.

Part of the Burmanization policy was the destruction of religious and cultural sites that did not align with Bamar style Buddhism. Scholars have referred to the process as "iconoclasm from above" whereby the junta destroyed cultural heritage as part of the state policy (Lee and Zarandona 2020). The junta's goal was to diminish both physical and cultural expressions of non-Bamar culture while promoting Bamar Buddhism (Noyes 2016). The junta did

not want to create a multi-ethnic, multi-religious secular state as envisioned by Aung San. Instead, the state was to be governed by Bamar Buddhist principles. The Burmanization campaign destroyed non-Buddhist icons and structures, particularly in states with non-Buddhist and non-Bamar residents, specifically the Chin, Kachin, Karen, and Rakhine states (US Department of State 2017; Sithu Aung Myint 2016). The destruction, closure, and conversion of buildings was part of the strategy of erasing the old identity and consolidating the new Bamar Buddhist identity. Multiple Islamic sites have been closed or destroyed. The Badar Makkam Mosque was annexed into a naval base during the 1970s and later used as a Buddhist site. In the 1980s, the Babagyi Mosque was occupied by the military and closed indefinitely to the public. Mosques in the town of Mrauk-U including the Musa Pali and Shindhikhan mosques were destroyed in the 1980s and 1990s respectively (Lee and Zarandona 2020). In 2012, the culturally and historically important Jama mosque in Sittwe was ransacked amid ongoing violence targeting the Rohingya; the mosque has not since reopened.

Buddhist nationalism in Myanmar has long aligned with the goals of the state, even as the state began democratizing. Buddhist nationalism in Myanmar has centered around marginalizing, and in some cases, attempting to eliminate forces that threaten the Bamar Buddhist majority. In the 1980s, the government began taking increasingly aggressive actions to erase the historical and cultural identity of the Rohingya, including: removing the Rohingya from the list of recognized groups within the state, stripping Rohingya of their citizenship cards, destroying cultural heritage sites, forced removal of the group from their historical land, and systematic rape and murder. Beginning in 1988, the ruling junta began classifying the Rohingya as trespassers from Bangladesh. By the 1990s, the state began a relocation program that recruited Buddhists to move to the Rakhine state to offset what was perceived as a growing Muslim population (Wade 2019). Over the next two decades the state took multiple measures to limit opportunities and movement of the Rohingya, including admission bans at state-run institutions such as Sitwe University. Travel outside of the Rakhine state was also strictly controlled. The state also passed "Protection of Race and Religion" laws to limit interreligious marriages (Frydenlund 2017; White 2015). The state and its affiliated Buddhist militias sought to erase memories of the Rohingya's existence within the region.

The democratization and liberalization of Myanmar that began in 2011 brought hope for many Rohingya that human rights in the country would improve. However, violence targeting the Rohingya only escalated. In 2012, in the state of Rakhine, widespread violence broke out between Arakanese Buddhists and Rohingya Muslims who make up 63% and 34% of Rakhine populations

respectively . Tensions escalated between the two groups following the rape and murder of a Buddhist woman by Rohingya men (Wade 2019). The unrest led to a state of emergency that severely restricted travel of the Rohingya and allowed the military to administer the region. Unrest further escalated in the following weeks with violence impacting both groups, resulting in 90 deaths, 90,000 displacements, and 2500 homes burned (Human Rights Watch 2013).

Unrest spread to non-Rohingya Muslim areas in 2013 as well. Following a business dispute between a Muslim shop owner and Buddhist customer, mob violence broke out in Mandalay killing more than 40, mostly Muslims. Police failed to intervene and, in some cases, participated (International Crisis Group 2013). In Yangon, Buddhists burned more than 100 Muslim homes, shops, and mosques (Szep 2013). Riot police in Thaketa observed Buddhist residents destroying an Islamic school. Buddhist resident Min Thet Lin told reporters, "People don't want a mosque here" (Marshall 2013). Additional incidents of Buddhists destroying Muslim homes, mosques, and businesses occurred in Lashio (Shan state) and Kantbalu (Sagaing state) that same year. However, most of the incidents in these states were able to be contained and incidents of violence were sporadic. However, in Rakhine, the targeted destruction by Buddhist militias was systematic and increasingly supported by the state.

Two Buddhist nationalist militia groups, the 969 movement and Ma Ba Tha, originated around the same time of the increasing communal violence. The 969 movement, founded by Buddhist monk Ashin Wirathu in 2013, sought to oppose the expansion of Islam within Myanmar and to protect the country from "Bengalis."[2] Similarly, Ma Ba Tha (The Patriotic Association of Myanmar) was founded by Buddhist monks in 2014 to defend Buddhism from Islam in Myanmar. Over the next two years, the organizations led efforts to destroy mosques and Muslim properties and to remove Muslims, particularly Rohingya, from what they considered Buddhist lands (Wade 2019). This coincided with state-led efforts to relocate Bamar Buddhists to areas where the Rohingya had been forcefully removed and to build Bamar structures, including Buddhist temples (Lee and Zarandona 2020). Although the organizations were technically independent of the government, they were increasingly supported by senior officials in the government.

By late 2016, the state transitioned from limited engagement and covert support of Buddhist militia groups to openly adopting much of the militia strategies as state policy. The state also introduced limitations on inter-religious marriage and the number of children Muslims can have (Frydenlund 2017).

[2]The term Bengali is used to deny that the Rohingya belong to Myanmar and instead suggests they belong to Bangladesh.

By the end of 2017, in what UN and Human Rights officials have labelled acts of genocide, the state forces and Buddhist militias killed at least 24,000 Rohingya and utilized widespread sexual violence against at least 18,000 Rohingya women and girls (APHR 2018). A further 116,000 Rohingya faced physical abuse and 36,000 were thrown into fires. Another 700,000 fled the country, mostly to neighboring Bangladesh (Habib et al. 2018). At least 300 Rohingya villages were destroyed, including the mosques within those villages (Human Rights Watch 2018). The actions by the military were classified as an ethnic cleansing by several scholarly sources and international organizations, including the United Nations Human Rights Council (UNHRC 2018). In 2019 Gambia brought charges of genocide against Myanmar in the International Court of Justice (UNHRC 2018).

Buddhist nationalist leaders and sentiment wield power over both the pro-military Union Solidarity and Development Party and Aung San Suu Kyi's National League for Democracy (NLD). Despite previously including Muslims in the party, in the 2015 election neither party included any Muslim candidates (Nachemson 2020). To further limit representation, the state election commission cancelled the 2020 elections for the Rakhine state. However, the state had already stripped most Rohingya of voting rights in 2015. The removal of rights came alongside physical violence by both the state and state-sanctioned Buddhist militias. Consequently, the state of Rakhine and the Rohingya essentially had no national representation under the ruling parties. The NLD won the November 2020 election decisively, however, a military coup on January 31, 2021prevented the elected government from assuming office. It is unknown how the return to the military junta will impact the Rohingya, but it remains notable that the worst atrocities thus far occurred under Suu Kyi's semi-democratic regime.

The Republic of the Union of Myanmar, alongside Buddhist militias, has utilized systematic violence to eliminate evidence of Rohingya presence in Myanmar. By destroying the architectural and historical evidence of their presence, the militias and government attempted to justify their narrative that the Rohingya did, and had never, belonged. The targeted elimination of architectural representations of the Rohingya happened alongside widespread violence, forced movement, and state-sanctioned death. Destroying and preventing access to Rohingya religious sites were strategic efforts by the government and militias to demonstrate that the Rohingya did not, and had never, belonged to Myanmar.

Xinjiang: State Sanctioned Nationalist Violence

China's nationalist vision varies from the previous cases of Myanmar and India. Whereas Myanmar and India's cases are examples of religious nationalism targeting religious minorities, China's is secular nationalism that aligns with the one-party state's cultural and political vision. Nonetheless, similar tactics of cultural destruction have been utilized in all three cases. In China, minority groups that deviate from the state's envisioned singular identity are often punished. In the case of Xinjiang, this has escalated to genocidal levels, particularly since 2017. The destruction of religious texts and worship sites, including churches, Tibetan monasteries, and mosques has been a strategy utilized by the state since the Cultural Revolution from 1966–1976 (Grim and Finke 2010).

Xinjiang (meaning the new frontier in Mandarin) was incorporated into China as a province in 1884 under the Qing dynasty. The area was inhabited primarily by Muslims of Turkic descent. The region had a history of instability, uprising, and occasional attempts to establish independent Muslim states. China disputed the history of the region, stating that Xinjiang was part of China since the third century. Additionally, China claims that the religion of Islam was imposed from the Arab Empire and thus not indigenous to the region (The State Council Information Office of the People's Republic of China 2019). When the People's Republic of China (PRC) was formally established in 1949, local resistance in Xinjiang continued. The PRC made Xinjiang an autonomous region in 1955 as a concession to the non-Han Chinese in the region in hopes of quelling tensions. This policy is similar to what China did with other ethnic and religious minorities such as in Tibet or Inner Mongolia. However, these regions were not truly autonomous. Strict assimilation measures were enacted that limited the practice of minority religions (Heberer 2017). China also encouraged increased Han migration to the region. State-led suppression of minorities escalated during the Cultural Revolution. During this time, anything that deviated from Mao's vision of a unitary state was strongly discouraged and punished. Practicing certain religions, particularly Tibetan Buddhism and Islam, speaking in a language other than Chinese, eating certain cultural cuisines, and wearing traditional clothes, were all strongly discouraged (Ruser, Leibold, Munro, and Hoja 2020). During the Cultural Revolution, approximately 50% of all mosques in China were destroyed (Ruser, Leibold, Munro, and Hoja 2020).

As China liberalized following Mao's death, the government instituted changes in Xinjiang. Some of these changes, such as allowing the rapid rebuilding of mosques, indicated a potential new openness toward minority

religions. By the end of the 1990s, the number of new mosques nearly returned to pre-Cultural Revolution numbers (Ruser, Leibold, Munro, and Hoja 2020). At the same time, however, local Han leaders also feared that giving increased autonomy to the Uyghurs in Xinjiang would nurture instability and separatism, especially in the shadow of uprisings in neighboring Afghanistan and Iran (Mukherjee 2010). Over the following decades, occasional skirmishes and bomb attacks occurred in Urumqi, Xinjiang's capital, and in Beijing. These attacks were carried out by Uyghur separatists and provoked China's counter-terrorism response (Ruser, Leibold, Munro, and Hoja 2020).

China began reframing the Xinjiang issue in the shadow of the Global War on Terrorism in the twenty-first century. In 2008, the Xinjiang separatist group Turkistan Islamic Party (ETIM) warned of attacks targeting the Beijing summer Olympics. The threat targeting the Olympics, in addition to attacks throughout Xinjiang in 2008, led China to take an increasingly aggressive approach in Xinjiang. The government first targeted cultural sites that were considered non-compliant due to lack of electricity, failure to register with the state, or poor road access (Raza 2019). In 2014, China began exerting the need for "deradicalization" and "transformation through education" via the "Strike Hard Campaign Against Violent Terrorism" initiative (Doyon 2019; Zhou 2019). Historically, this approach targeted the Falun Gong but under the leadership of Communist Party Chief Zhang Chunxian, this program was drastically expanded to include additional religious minority groups, specifically the Uyghurs (Tong 2009; Greitens, Lee, and Yazici 2020).

Around the same time of this escalation and new policy approach, China reportedly began its "re-education" camps as part of the "people's war on terror." The camps are said to help "integrate" and "Sinicize" minorities into Chinese society. Although estimates vary, between 1.5–3 million ethnic and religious minorities, primarily Uyghurs and other Muslims, are said to be detained in the camps (Greitens, Lee, and Yazici 2020). This accounts for up to 10% of the total Uyghur population. The policy of the camps is to eliminate cultural practices that do not align with Sino identity such as beards, hijabs, fasting, abstention of pork, and use of traditional Muslim names for children such as Muhammad (Denyer 2020). Additional reports detail forced contraception and/or sterilization of Uyghur women (Associated Press 2020).

Alongside the elimination of non-Sino cultural practices, China has actively destroyed religious sites of the Uyghurs. Using satellite evidence, a report by the Australian Strategic Policy Institute found that 16,000 mosques in Xinjiang (65% of the total) have been destroyed or damaged since 2017. Of those mosques, 8,500 were completely demolished. Additionally, an estimated 30% of all sacred sites were destroyed with an additional 28% damaged or

altered. These sites include shrines, cemeteries, and pilgrimage sites (Ruser, Leibold, Munro, and Hoja 2020). This systematic elimination of sacred sites in conjunction with "re-education" camps by the Chinese government is an attempt to demonstrate that culture outside the narrowly defined Chinese state identity is not welcomed.

Conclusion

This article discussed how the destruction of cultural and religious sites of minority Muslims has been used as a nationalist tactic in India, Myanmar, and Xinjiang, China. In all three cases, the perpetrator has attempted to demonstrate that the targeted group did not historically belong to the land and posed a current security threat. Such historical revisionism attempts to re-frame national identities. In India, Hindu nationalists considered the Babri Masjid a sign of historical Muslim aggression. Destroying the Babri Masjid was seen as correcting a historical wrong and asserting Hindu authority over a sacred space in Ayodhya. In Myanmar, Rohingya Muslims are framed as recent, and violent, illegal immigrants who threaten to destroy the Buddhist nature of Myanmar. Buddhist militias, in conjunction with the state, have destroyed or converted multiple Islamic sites as well as forced removals of the Rohingya population. These violent acts occurred after increasingly aggressive measures by the state to limit the agency and autonomy of the Rohingya. Finally, approximately 16,000 mosques have been damaged or destroyed in Xinjiang, China. Unlike India and Myanmar, China's policy has been carried out almost exclusively by the state. China's mosque destruction was also not done in the name of religious nationalism. Instead, it was carried out as part of a state-led secular nationalist vision. However, in all three cases, the perpetrators justify their actions by framing Muslims as security threats.

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